

Helarctos malayanus

Sun bear



Length 3–5 ft (1–1.5 m)
Tail 1–2½ in (3–7 cm)
Weight 66–155 lb (30–70 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Vulnerable

Location S.E. Asia



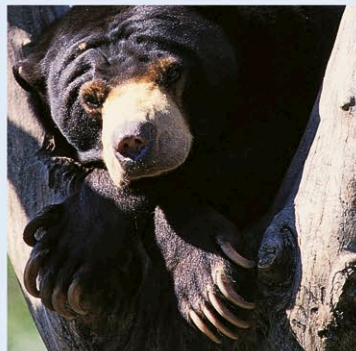
The only truly tropical bear, the sun bear is an elusive, nocturnal, little-known omnivore of hardwood lowland forest. Its sleek, smooth fur varies from black to gray or rusty. It is paler on the muzzle, which is comparatively short. Its stocky, doglike body proportions and small size have led to the local name of dog bear. The sun bear spends much time in

trees, even sleeping in a rough nest of bent-over or broken branches. It eats a range of fruit, shoots, eggs, small mammals, grubs, honey (its other name is honey bear), and varied plant food. Habitat loss, as forests are logged and converted to agriculture, is the major threat to the species, and it may raid crops, notably palm-tree plantations for the shoots, leading to persecution by farmers.

white to reddish “sun” chest patch varies from a U-shape to a circle or irregular spot

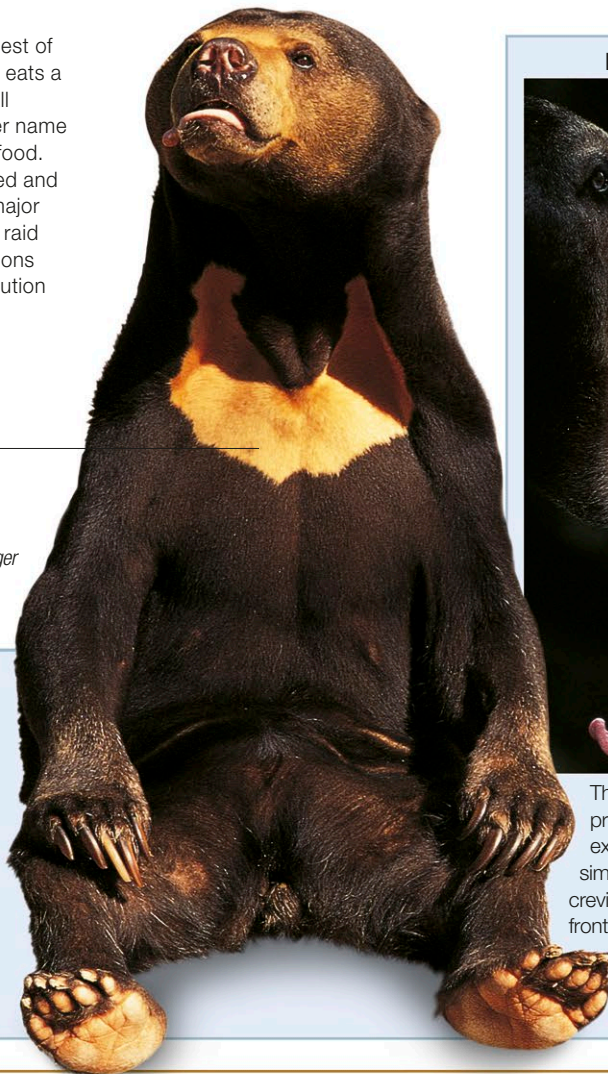
SMALLEST BEAR

The smallest bear species, the sun bear also has the shortest fur. If seized by a tiger or other predator, the loose skin around its neck allows it to turn and fight.

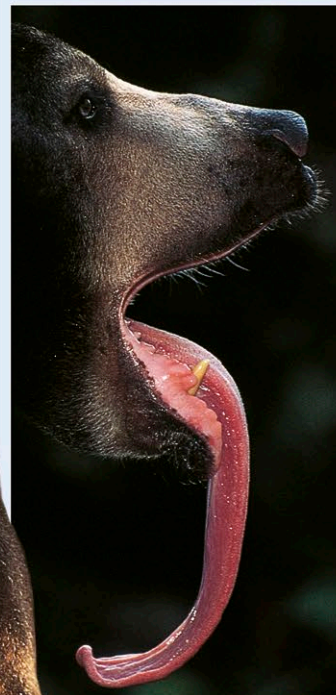


CLIMBING CLAWS

The sun bear has large front feet with extremely long, curved claws, an adaptation for tree climbing. It also hugs the trunk with its front limbs and grips with its teeth, to haul itself up. The claws are also used to dig for worms and insects, and to break into termite colonies and nests of stingless bees.



LONG TONGUE



The sun bear’s tongue can protrude 10 in (25 cm) to extract grubs, honey, and similar food from holes and crevices. It may also place each front paw alternately in a termite nest; the occupants crawl onto the paw, and the bear then licks them off.

Melursus ursinus

Sloth bear



Length 4½–6 ft (1.4–1.8 m)
Tail 2¾–4¾ in (7–12 cm)
Weight 120–420 lb (55–190 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Vulnerable

Location S. Asia



This small to medium-sized bear has a stocky body and short, powerful limbs. It can survive in a variety of habitats, including thorn scrub, grassland, and forest, if its 3 major foods—ants, termites, and fruit—are present (it also eats honey and eggs). Its long, nonretractile

white chest mark varies from a U-shape to a “Y” or “O”

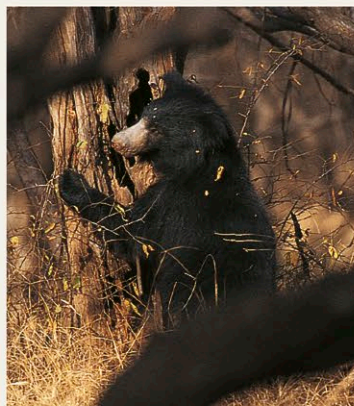
SHAGGY BEAR

The sloth bear is distinguished by its long, rough fur, especially around the ears, rear neck, and shoulders. Color varies from black to brown or reddish; the muzzle is usually much paler or even white.



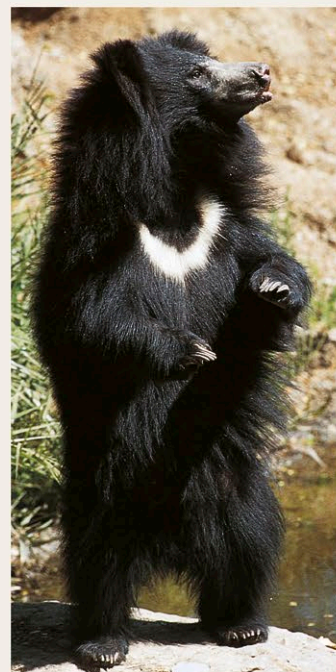
ON THE SCENT

Bears locate food mainly by smell, sniffing with their long, mobile snout. The sloth bear specializes in ants and termites, tearing open their nests in soil, old logs, or trees with its foreclaws, which are 3 in (8 cm) long. Closing its nostrils and pursing its lips, it sucks the insects through the gap formed by its missing upper incisor teeth. The sucking noises it makes can be heard up to 330 ft (100 m) away.



foreclaws (see panel above) help it to get food and are useful for climbing trees, too. Like other bears, the adult sloth bear is mainly solitary except during the mating season (June–July). However, brief groupings of 5–7 young bears have been observed, even without local concentrations of food to attract them. The female occupies a natural hollow or digs one, and usually has 2 cubs (in November–January). The cubs stay in the den for 2–3 months, ride on the mother’s back clinging to her long fur for another 6 months, and become independent after about 2 years. Threats include habitat loss, poaching for body parts (used in traditional medicines), persecution, and cub capture for training and performance.

STANDING SURVEY



Like other bears, the sloth bear can stand just on its back legs. Once believed to be an aggressive posture, the bear is in fact gaining a clearer view of its surroundings and, more importantly, scenting the air to assess possible food or danger. Injuries to humans, mainly clawings, are usually the result of surprise encounters.